

COVID-19 and digital library services: an overview on legal information

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to investigate the initiatives providing legal information during the COVID-19 emergency, focusing on the fundamental role of digital libraries in creating, managing and sharing services to support and ensure access to legal information in times of emergency.

Design/methodology/approach – To have an overall view of the legal information on COVID-19 available on digital libraries during the outbreak, a desk-research on the Web was conducted looking for both public and private sources of information. The selection of the sources was based on the type of information and services offered, the quality of information structuring, together with the data updating and the target users.

Findings – The survey provided a huge and heterogeneous amount of legal information resources on COVID-19. The analysis on the source of information selected showed different kinds of approaches adopted by digital libraries in relation to types of information provided, information categorization, target audiences, purposes and services offered.

Research limitations/implications – Two limitations have been identified: lack of previous studies in the domain and size of the samples cited. The conducted research should be seen as the “building block” upon which further research should be broadened and deepened. Limited samples are cited because of a rational choice; nevertheless, future research should be conducted also addressing a quantitative choice on identifying sources.

Practical implications – The research proposes to give users practical guidance, namely, a first set of authoritative sources which gives legal information on COVID-19.

Originality/value – This review paper could be seen as a first study on the issues related to accessing and sharing legal data at the time of the COVID-19; the research could be a starting point for devising a new form of communication of legal information in times of crisis.

Keywords Digital libraries, Rule of law, COVID-19, Access to law, Knowledge of the law, Legal information

Paper type General review

1. Knowledge of the law: an introduction

The knowledge of the law affects every area of people's life: law represents indeed the operating system of a society (*ubi societas ibi jus*). If the nature of the law is so pervasive, it becomes essential for everyone to know and to identify the consequences of one's own behaviors. Being acquainted with law essentially means that the consequences of our behavior as well as of our omission, negligence or even the passing of time must be clear to us. This is what is meant by legal certainty, the principle that ensures the realization of the principle of the rule of law (Gordillo, 2014, p. 48), representing the result of a very long and complex history that coincides with the transition from common law to codified law, from the *ancien régime* to the modern liberal state.

In particular, in emergency periods such as the COVID-19 pandemic, supporting access to law including rights awareness and understanding of court procedures are indeed



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necessary. The impact of the crisis as well as the legal and policy responses implemented by states to counter the spread of COVID-19 have much wider unwelcome consequences that affect a broad range of human rights, including the ability of people to access justice in a fair and effective manner. In such a context, advocacy and legal information campaigns are of fundamental importance. On one hand, some issues arise related to the temporary suspension or limitation of some fundamental rights, on the other, constitutional rights such as the right of access must be ensured. The right of access is essential for monitoring the transparency and accountability of governments, regions and even minor local authorities precisely in the management of events like this. The choices and actions of today's governments are in fact fundamental for our future.

It is a matter of fact that law is not really knowable to everybody. The Roman legal principle *nemo censetur ignore legem* (it is assumed that no one ignores the law) is one of the most noticeable absolute fiction, and at the same time one of the most essential, as if the excuse of ignorance of the law was accepted, anyone could misuse it in any situation (van Caenegem, 1991, pp. 139–140).

Legal provisions are known only by those who are able to find them, understand them and place them correctly in the regulatory system. The sources of production are manifold, the laws are subject to continuous changes over time and this makes it difficult to know the current provisions that regulate a certain matter at a given moment. Furthermore, the laws are subject to interpretation by judges of various levels who interpret unequivocally, who fill gaps, which literally create new rules. Finally, in addition to the norms and jurisprudence, also legal doctrine, as the set of comments on provisions and jurisprudence produced by jurists and legal practitioners plays a fundamental role in the knowledge of the law.

In particular, in the emergency periods such as the one we are living now, the countless provisions and related interpretative indications, often contradictory and misleading, have made it very difficult to extricate in a labyrinth of rules, with serious repercussions on citizens about which behaviors are prohibited and which are lawful.

At operative level, to ensure the principle of the rule of law during the pandemic emergency, citizens should be supported by specific and user-oriented measures for accessing legal information resources (Bhardwaj, 2019). Everyone should be provided with proper tools and services; governments all over the world have an obligation to put forth legal knowledge by enabling access to the law using all available and reasonable media (Peruginelli, 2006).

Full availability of comprehensive, updated and relevant legal information represents the strategy to even out access to law to everybody (Peruginelli, 2016). The result is hopefully a non-discriminatory society giving access to online, free of charge information, freed from legal restrictions (Suber, 2004). This creates the necessary conditions for achieving equity and fairness of a legal system, thus improving the operation of democratic institutions.

2. Context and purpose of the study

This paper intends to focus its attention on the available resources for accessing legal information in times of emergency such as the pandemic of COVID-19. In this specific situation, the citizen, without specific legal knowledge, needs “prepackaged” information, able to summarize a specific legal situation and to offer, in a language devoid of technicalities, the different solutions that, on a regulatory and jurisprudential level, could have a specific legal question. This means creating simple, but continuously updated and organized legal documentation around the concrete needs of citizens who try to face a situation of extreme emergency strongly affecting their practical life (family, work, health, etc.).

At the time of COVID-19, the implementation and development of digital services coming from different data sources seem to be an adequate response to these needs. In addition to the general services for all citizens, legal services dedicated to specific law related issues impacted by COVID-19 (health, work, safety, etc.) and to specific categories of citizens and professionals (legal experts, local administrations, entrepreneurs, etc.) have been developed. This solution experimented in most of the world was also followed by the big publishing houses in the development of online legal information. In this context, digital libraries play a decisive role in supporting the sharing and communication of legal information. Here, the digital library has a specific meaning that certainly incorporates numerous existing definitions (Lesk, 1997; Borgman, 2000; Bishop *et al.*, 2003) [1], but which is not exclusively linked to the library environment. As reported in the International Federation of Library Associations and Institutions (IFLA)/United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) Manifesto 2011:

[...]the digital library serves as an environment to bring together collections, services, and people in support of the full life cycle of creation, dissemination, use and preservation of data, information and knowledge [...] Within a digital library collections are created, managed and made accessible in such a way that they are readily and economically available for use by a defined community or set of communities (IFLA Governing Board, 2007).

It is precisely on the basis of this definition and of the social role of digital libraries that this paper has been conceived and drafted.

The objective of this paper is to investigate initiatives providing legal information during the COVID-19 emergency and the way they provide this kind of information. A panorama of services for accessing legal information coming from actors who are involved in the sharing and communication of legal data at the time of COVID-19 has been provided.

The topic is not supported by references texts. Many are the legal resources (provisions, regulations, administrative acts, etc.) published by institutional websites (governmental bodies) and by private legal firms, and no specific literature is available. There are some documents addressing peculiar issues related to the real-life impact of this pandemic on the justice system, but they are not specifically focused on accessing legal information (United Nations Development Programme - UNDP and United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime – UNODC, 2020; Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development – OECD, 2020). They deal with accessing to justice in face of COVID-19 and concerns the identification of good practices and experiences in enhancing access to justice from both citizen and business perspectives.

On the basis of lack of the literature review on the topic, a specific analysis reported in this paper has been carried out to offer a glance on some of the services available for accessing legal information with a particular focus on the library environment as the appropriate institution to share legal information for all. Focusing on the fundamental role of digital libraries in creating, managing and sharing services to support and ensure access to legal information in times of emergency, the paper tries to identify the features of digital services of this kind pointing out strengths and weaknesses of the actual services. The study was carried out by IGSG – Institute of Legal Informatics and Judicial Systems of the National Research Council of Italy in May 2020.

3. Materials and methods

A small desk research on the Web was conducted looking for both public and private sources of legal information on COVID-19.

The information sources investigated in the public sphere were those of local and national libraries, law libraries, universities, research institutes, European institutions, international organizations and professional associations. As regards private sources, we tracked services of companies and publishers specialized in legal documentation.

We were primarily interested in having an overview of digital resources on legal information offered by libraries, considering those specialized in law resources but also general ones (both national and local). The purpose of this focus was to understand how libraries offered this kind of information on their digital channels to the different target audiences.

To have a wider understanding of how legal information on COVID-19 was provided during the outbreak, the research was broadened by investigating other public and private bodies as mentioned above. We deliberately decided not to include government institutions in this research. Government institutions, which are entrusted with making and enforcing legislation and rules, generally provide in their websites legal information sources pertaining to their jurisdiction and regulating new events which impact society. We decided not to track this legal information, but to focus the research on how different public and private bodies collect, illustrate and share it at the time of COVID-19. In this way, the research gave a wider panorama of digital libraries legal information sharing on the topic.

The research was conducted on English language resources only, with the exception of the bibliographic legal resource produced by IGSG-CNR (DoGi Database, see sub-paragraph 5.2), that is a national source available in Italian.

From this research, a number of resources (27) that provided a wide array of legal information on COVID-19 were selected.

This selection was based on our intention of showing the resources that provide significant examples of how legal information on COVID-19 was made available on the Web. The selected resources, indeed, allowed us to have an overview of the different types of legal information and services offered. In addition, they refer to diverse target audiences, from common citizens to legal experts. And, moreover, show different ways of structuring the information connected to the varied purposes of the data collection.

Every resource, selected to give a representative panorama of the legal information available, was described through a structured grid so as to analyze and compare them. We have considered the type of information provided, its purpose, the structuring and services offered together with the reference target audience.

The grid is structured as described as follows.

In the “Resource name,” “Source of data” and “Type of Source of data” fields, we reported the title of the collection of legal information, the name of the institution or company that produced it and its type of information source. We then examined how the data collection was structured and to what kind of audience the content was targeted (such as legal operators, civil servants, academics, students of law, entrepreneurs or ordinary citizens).

Another element of the investigation was to identify the “purpose” of the data collection: we wanted to trace what was the goal of the data collection, not only what was expressly stated by the service but also what was implied, which we were able to identify thanks to the structure and type of resources provided.

The grid also reported the type of legal information provided by the data stakeholder. Documentation used in legal research is generally divided into two broad categories: primary sources and secondary sources. Primary legal sources are the actual law in the form of constitutions, court cases, statutes and administrative rules and regulations. Secondary legal sources discuss, analyze, describe, explain or critique the law. Secondary sources are used to help locate primary sources of law, define legal words and phrases or help in legal

research. In the following table, primary sources consist of sources that state the actual law and explanatory secondary sources consist of sources that explain, criticize, discuss or help locate primary law. A third type of material is also envisaged, that is the one usually addressed to lay people, such as informative notes and information fact sheets that have the aim of explaining legal content in an easy and smart way.

Finally, through the “Services offered” field of the grid, we wanted to verify what services were provided connected to the resource, namely, what content the institution/company produced to make the legal information more available or more comprehensible for the target audience.

4. Results and discussion

As a general observation, we can state that the Web provided a huge but also heterogeneous amount of legal information resources on COVID-19, both from public and from private bodies. This is clearly connected to the extraordinary interest ordinary citizens and legal operators have in the topic. Of course, this is because of the fact that this unexpected emergency situation has unavoidable legal implications and consequences.

Adding to the specific resources under investigation, a special analysis was conducted on the DoGi (Dottrina Giuridica) database, a reference bibliographic database of articles published in Italian legal journals, managed by IGSG-CNR. The special attention given to this data collection was to focus on the specific type of legal information, that is legal doctrine on COVID-19, so to give an overview of the main issues and trends tackled in the Italian legal doctrine.

As regards the library category, the type of source of data collection considered significant for our research included six law libraries (the Sacramento County Public Law Library, the San Diego Law Library, the LA Law Library, the Pace Law School Library, the Law Library of Victoria and the UCLA School of Law, Law library), three national libraries (the Library of Congress, the National Library of Australia and the Homeland Security Digital Library), one state library (the Florida Department of State – Division of Library and Information Services) and one city library (the Newmarket Public Library).

4.1 Findings on digital resources examined

From this amount of information, we chose to record institutional sources (of different categories) and private ones only, based on the criteria described in the methodology.

The university data collection selected pertained to the University of Oxford (Law Faculty), The Chinese University of Hong Kong and the AfricanLII, a program of the Democratic Governance and Rights Unit at the Department of Public Law, University of Cape Town, whereas for the research institutes, the Uganda Legal Information Institute was consulted.

As for the European institutions, the European Union, the Council of European Union and European Banking Authority websites were considered interesting for the aim of the search.

International organizations that provided interesting legal information on COVID-19 were the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC), the Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development, the International Labour Organization and the Council of Europe.

As for the private companies, Deloitte Legal network and LexisNexis were the ones selected in the search, whereas for the private publishers, we consulted Brill and Martindale-Hubbell.

Finally, for the category of professional associations, the American Bar Association was analyzed.

All of the resources mentioned are freely accessible with the exception of private company and private publisher ones.

One of the principal post-search considerations was whether the institution/company produced its own content or whether its website provided external resources. Naturally,

European institutions provide their own legal information: in the European Union websites, European Commission's recommendations on COVID-19 are made available as well as recommendations of the Council of the European Union, and documents of the European Banking Authority on the topic are accessible from their websites.

Also international organizations, such as the United Nations and the Council of Europe provide their own official documents on COVID-19 such as the UNODC COVID-19 policy and the "Toolkit on respecting human rights, democracy and the rule of law during the COVID-19 crisis" produced by the Council of Europe.

Local libraries do not directly produce primary legal information but their important role in this context is to make local and national resources available on their websites, and in doing so, they act as a guarantee of the quality of the information provided, helping users to find trustful information. As stated by the Sacramento County Public Law Library, "The Sacramento County Public Law Library has created this page to help our community find reliable information on legal topics related to the COVID-19 pandemic" [2].

They, however, produce in some cases information sheets and other explanatory texts to make the resources easy to find and understand.

Law libraries, universities and research institutes, instead, provide secondary sources on their websites that explain and analyze the primary legal resources whose full texts are made available through links to public authority websites.

Finally, private companies as well produce resources such as "summary of legal acts," articles or information notes that have the aim of explaining norms and regulations in technical terms.

Looking at the structure of the legal information resources found on the websites selected, we can identify seven different categories.

The first and most common categorization is based on geographical areas, such as the one used by AfricanLII, where the legal resources are divided in relation to the different African countries, without any other subclassifications, or as in the case of the Pace Law School Library that provides the link to the main norms on COVID-19 for every American state.

Local libraries, instead, tend to use thematic categories to organize the resources provided, as in the case of the Sacramento County Public Law Library, the Newmarket Public Library and the San Diego Law Library, which also use images to make the different categories more easily accessible (health, employment, housing, etc.).

Other strategies used to classify legal contents are those based on the type of the resources (for example "Regulations" and "Judiciary circulars" of the Uganda Legal Information Institute website), and the different sources of the content as done by the University of Oxford for their own resources (Border Criminologies blog, Centre of Criminology, Oxford Business Law Blog and The Oxford University Undergraduate Law Journal).

The European Union on its website instead organizes the legal information according to the goal of the resource, so as to clarify what need that information is covering, such as "Limiting the spread of the virus," "Ensuring the provision of medical equipment," "Boosting research for treatments and vaccines" and "Supporting jobs."

Private publishers categorize the resources dividing them in accordance with the different areas of law (commercial law, finance and banking law, labor law, etc).

Finally, a few of the sources chose to present the content by only listing them in alphabetical order or, in some cases, without any particular structure.

As for the intended target audience of legal information on COVID-19, this one is rarely clearly indicated on the analyzed websites, with few exceptions.

The audience is, however, identifiable by the type of the resources provided on the different websites and from the topics indicated. In the majority of cases examined, legal information is addressed to every citizen, but as a matter of fact, ordinary citizens could

have some difficulties in understanding the full text of primary legal sources. Therefore, it is possible to affirm that when this kind of legal information is available, legal professionals are the most appropriate recipients.

Legal scientific articles and in general secondary legal sources found on the websites considered will be interesting for academics, researchers and students of Law.

We also found specific informative contents produced for entrepreneurs, or specific categories of citizens such as employers and employees.

Local libraries provide useful content for the general public, such as the Sacramento County Public Law library that created easy information sheets related to different legal topics. In every fact sheets, links to institutional resources suitable for lay people such as frequently asked questions, guides and explanatory charts are also indicated.

Legal information on the website of the European Union is also directed to the citizens: contents are summarized and explained using plain language and a clear information architecture.

In other cases, simplified contents that introduce or explain legal resources to non-expert users are not provided in sources that should be directed to all, such as national libraries, and their content therefore remains inaccessible to non-expert audiences.

Finally, as regards the purpose of the document collections of the identified websites, it is naturally an informative one, distinguishing between general information, aimed above all at updating the resources that are gradually produced on the evolution of the emergency by more professional information addressed to legal professionals.

Another different purpose identified was that of the Nation Library of Australia, which aims to collect government and local administration information and advice through webpage snapshots for the purpose of historical conservation. This, as stated on the website, to make them available for future generations that did not live in this (hopefully) unique era.

A summary table of the analyzed selected resources is shown below (Table 1).

4.2 Overview on Italian legal doctrine on COVID-19: the case of the DoGi – Dottrina Giuridica database

Legal information shows particular characteristics related to its specific nature, diverse objectives and uses made of it, while enhancing a strong integration of its different sources: legislation, jurisprudence (case-law) and doctrine (scholarship).

It is of the utmost importance to give wider access to such sources for ensuring their knowledge.

In particular, legal doctrine plays a key role in integrating various types of information. It includes a huge number of scientific literature produced by different legal sources and focuses on interpretation and understanding of rules and judgments as described and commented by legal scholars. In the meanwhile, legal literature does reflect the legal debate within an ever growing and constantly changing society (Agnoloni *et al.*, 2013, p. 227).

In an emergency context, providers of legal doctrine do have an essential function in presenting and understanding the legislative products of the regulatory state and in interpreting case law.

In this context, the IGSG-CNR produces, manages and distributes the DoGi – Dottrina Giuridica database since 1970, the year of its foundation [3]. The corpus includes approximately 250 print and electronic legal journals published by Italian publishers and is considered the most comprehensive source of online information on Italian legal doctrine.

The DoGi database offers a huge panorama of articles, case notes, reviews/comments of legislation and case law, reports on conferences and critical reviews, which reflects the “state of the art” of the Italian debate on law and it indexed such resources [4].

Table 1.
Investigation matrix
of the analyzed
digital libraries

Resource name and source of data collection	27 resources analyzed E.g.: Resource name: "COVID-19 Legal Issues" Source of data collection: "San Diego Law Library"
Type of source of data collection	Law library, university law library, national library, local library, European institution, international organization, private company, publisher and professional association
Structure	Resources divided into sections/topics Resources divided into sections based on geographical areas Resources based on legal information types Resources divided according to their goals, so as to clarify which needs are satisfying Resources organized in accordance with the different areas of law Resources listed in alphabetical order Resources divided into specific learning materials
Target audience	Ordinary citizen, civil servant, legal professional, entrepreneur, academic and student of law
Purposes of data collection	To provide informative purposes in specific activities of life To provide complete legal information on the different domains involved To provide advisory information on the current situation To provide complete legal information and resources for professional and academic purposes To provide a list of legal information resources on COVID-19 from relevant sources with a special focus on local legal information To provide specific and detailed informative purposes providing links to primary sources and high-quality summaries To preserve information to make it available for future generations
Type of provided information	Primary sources, secondary sources, explanatory secondary sources, information fact sheets and information notes
Services offered	External links to websites and resources Internal sources of information completed by external links to websites Collection of legal-administrative information resources Online seminars on the topic Summary of the different legal provisions and full text available Collection of scientific contributions Collection of government and local administration information and advice through webpage snapshots Virtual meetings, interviews, blogs, webinars and on-demand products Basic assistance by phone and by email

The value of the DoGi database consists in the interaction and integration of different resources which provide access to legal doctrine. Not only bibliographic references are indexed, but also legislation and case law are cited in the text.

The structure of the DoGi record, with access to legislation and case law cited in the article, with a reference to a legal classification, gives legal professionals, academics, researchers as well as citizens, the opportunity to obtain an extended panorama of current legal issues and to have access to scholarship publications useful to resolve legal cases (Agnoloni *et al.*, 2013, p. 228).

In the emergency situation such the pandemic of COVID-19, the database allows its users to know and understand specific legal issues which have an impact on daily life during the pandemic and post-pandemic periods. The spread of COVID-19 is having significant legal implications across different sectors of the society and the DoGi database intends to render the

coronavirus-related journal articles immediately accessible for academics, legal professionals, students, researchers and ordinary citizens.

Launching two keyword searches (COVID-19 and coronavirus) within the whole documentary record, the DoGi database gives back 51 results, consisting of publications in Italian legal journals dealing with the emergency situation.

Considering that the search covered the Italian legal journals published in the past three months, the results highlight the high impact of this topic in the Italian legal literature.

The table below describes the identified results of the search: area of law which the publication refers to, type of journal (indexed in DoGi) in which the article is published and type of publication.

For each different category identified in the table, the number of results of the keyword search has been indicated (Table 2).

It is to be noticed that the Italian debate on legal issues related to COVID-19 mainly focused within the civil law domain, moreover a specific attention is given to the area of commercial law, probably because of the high impact of the coronavirus crisis in the economic sector.

As for the type of publication, legal information on COVID-19 mostly referred to articles instead of case notes: as a result of court closures and reduced operations, proceedings have been delayed and few were the disputes related to pandemic in the first semester of 2020.

Finally, the database search has highlighted that compared to online journals, print reviews represent the appropriate place to examine these issues. The reason may lie in the fact that Italian legal journals are considered by academics to be more prestigious than exclusively online ones.

Apart from the results of the DoGi search, what is worth mentioning is the attention the legal doctrine pays to legal issues related to COVID-19, which meets the main challenge posed by the pandemic: ensuring as wide access as possible to legal information for improving knowledge and awareness on the topic.

5. Limitations and practical implications

The research encountered some limitations which can somehow be considered also challenges for the next future work analysis. The investigation was conducted on English language resources and no comparative analysis among different jurisdictions and legal systems has been carried out. The coverage tried to include all the continents with a difference on number of resources under investigation. The observation considered only the resources which are active in offering legal information on COVID-19. Another constrain is the lack of previous studies in the research area, due to the sudden emergency situation and to the evolving nature of legal information at the time of COVID-19.

Area of law	Civil law: 28 Criminal law: 4 Commercial law: 9 Administrative law: 5 Tax law: 3 Civil procedure law: 2
Type of journal	Paper journal: 28 Online journal (public access): 0
Type of publication	Article: 49 Case notes: 2

Table 2.
Legal doctrine results
on COVID-19 in DoGi
database

On the other hand, this limitation has been considered an interesting starting point to increase and develop discussion and debate on collection, management and sharing of legal information related to COVID-19.

The analysis should be seen as the “building block” upon which further research should be broadened and deepened.

Furthermore, the size of the sample of the study has been limited.

It is to be taken into consideration that this limit originated from a specific and rational choice. Several sources of legal information at the time of COVID-19 have been found online, nevertheless the research opted for a qualitative choice rather than quantitative.

It is important that individuals rely on authoritative sources to get updated and trustful information, as well as legal information, on the COVID-19 outbreak. Raising awareness of the dangers of disinformation and promoting the use of authoritative sources is the only way to tackle disinformation itself, especially in situations of emergency, such as coronavirus-related crisis. Of course, qualitative choice of sources of legal information on COVID-19 fits the first approach to the research area. Future research should be conducted also addressing a quantitative choice on identifying sources, to give as many samples as possible on how legal information is provided at the time of pandemic.

A comparative analysis of all the samples (coming from both qualitative and quantitative choice) should be further carried on to highlight the different criteria adopted to give access to legal information at the time of COVID-19.

As regards practical implication raised from the analysis it is to be noted that digital libraries show more and more updated content and do manage targeted collections on COVID-19-related legal issues, thus individuals can have an in-depth knowledge on the topic.

As previously mentioned, in their “Manifesto for Digital Libraries,” UNESCO and the IFLA pointed out that: “The mission of the digital library is to give direct access to information resources [...] in a structured and authoritative manner [...]” (IFLA Governing Board, 2007).

The importance of digital libraries as a knowledge hub and their contribution to development of legal knowledge and awareness on COVID-19-related legal issues is well defined. The services analyzed offer a sort of practical guidance to users, namely, a first set of authoritative sources which offer a first glance on legal information related to COVID-19.

Although the size of samples would not seem to be exhaustive, the categories identified provide users with practical information on how to move online even beyond the analyzed websites. An extensive analysis of other data sources is ongoing. The intent is to cluster these data sources according to geographical areas so to investigate different countries and their national strategies of accessing the law.

6. Final remarks

Effective knowledge of the law becomes even more important and indispensable in times of emergency when people have the right and duty to know what they must and can do, what is prohibited and what is lawful. In these times of health crisis, the communication of legal information should find a way to emerge with authority and complete information in the *mare magnum* of disinformation, fake news and conflicting indications.

Over the past few months, the progressive spread of the COVID-19 virus has aroused great concern within the public opinion and has asked national and supranational institutions for a prompt and effective response for the containment of pandemic risk and for the management of emergency. To deal with such epidemic risks, it is certainly up to the public bodies (in particular, the executive ones) belonging to the various institutional levels to adopt the most appropriate regulatory and administrative measures. In such a context, communication has a significant impact on the effectiveness of these measures actually implemented. The communicative function

becomes more difficult to exercise in so far when it concerns legal information and related issues and implications.

In particular, the moment of extreme emergency that we have experienced and are still experiencing requires a virtual space where we can find detailed answers to specific legal questions that are asked by different target audiences. The social role of the digital library as a community center in close alignment with the needs of the communities is crucial.

This analysis tries to offer an overview of what is available at the moment, highlighting the different types of sources, the methods of communication and the purposes. The study has shown that there is no clear and strategic planning for legal information access and knowledge.

The information available is often disrupted and incomplete thus creating confusion for users. There are no specific routes for specific categories of users (expert and non-expert). Legal information is often complementary to more general information. Furthermore, legal information is not often updated, producing a sense of frustration in the user who does not know whether to trust it or not.

The digital library, and in particular the digital law library, could play a central role in taking charge of legal communication in an emergency or crisis situation. The so-called “crisis communication” should be centralized and deeply organized, requiring planning and, above all, should be prepared “in peace time.”

To the best of the authors’ knowledge, this paper could be seen as a first study on the issues related to accessing and sharing legal data at the time of the COVID-19: the analysis should be seen as a starting point for devising a new form of communication of legal information in times of crisis.

Furthermore, this research could be the basis for assessing the effectiveness and the relevance of the legal content provided during COVID-19 by various public bodies for the diverse target audiences and especially for lay people. In fact, in addition to being available, regulatory information should be accessible and understood by the public as well as appropriate to its needs (Skopal, 2017). An initial step of this possible investigation should analyze how the information is structured, to understand if it is suitable to favor the accessibility of the legal information for the different target audiences.

This future study, in line with the user-centered design approach, should start with an analysis phase aimed at identifying users’ characteristics and needs and usage scenarios. The content evaluation methods will then be chosen based on the analysis results and involve representative groups of users (Sharp *et al.*, 2019).

Notes

1. Among others definitions: “Organized collections of digital information. They combine the structuring and gathering of information, which libraries have always done, with the digital representation of information that computers have made possible” (Lesk, 1997); “Digital libraries are constructed – collected and organized – by [and for] a community of users, and their functional capabilities support the information needs and uses of that community” (Borgman, 2000); “Sociotechnical systems – networks of technology, information, documents, people, and practices” (Bishop *et al.*, 2003).
2. The Sacramento County Public Law Library, available at: <https://saclaw.org/law-101/coronavirus-covid-19>
3. DoGi – Dottrina Giuridica database, available at: www.ittig.cnr.it/dogi/
4. The DoGi database includes 456.113 records (updated in April 2020). DoGi is freely available online with the only limitation of 200 documents visualized per day.

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